

Chapter 70a - Imbalance of a Head

IT is often seen in whaling that a ship may come across a group of ten or more whales swimming together, and swimming just near the surface, it can sometimes appear as a wave of dark bodies undulating and rippling through the water. These pods offer a mountainous trove of oil, should any number of them be taken by a ship with harpooners skilled and brave enough to face more than a single leviathan at one time.

And when, upon the end of the chase, the carcass is lifted alongside the ship, stripped of its living flesh, and dropped astern forever to wander the seas as a phantom of its former self, the head, when lifted to the port or starboard side, drags even the greatest of ships into a tilt, threatening to drag the vessel down into the depths with the leviathan's unliving corpse. No amount of straining, lifting, or hauling on the part of any crew, dead, living, or not yet alive, could force that head to give up its weight and float the ship upright in the waters. Nay, not even Ahab, who has seen more whales and whale-bones than any alive could compel that brute to release its death-hold on a ship.

So what then, must be done to avoid such an unbalanced, un-sailable position? Must any act be taken at all? For, indeed, while the skull of a whale hangs alongside a ship, it is normal for the crew to occupy themselves with harvesting it, repairing their implements of hunting, and relaxing after the long chase. Little sailing is necessary, and a ship may safely balance, drifting between the upright position it should rightly hold, and the void of the deep sea.

When it comes time to set sail, the head can be easily dropped and the ship set upright again, free to continue on its unholy voyage. Unhindered by the head and unbound from the dead weight of the whale, a ship may begin the hunt once again, burdened only by the riches sealed in the hold.

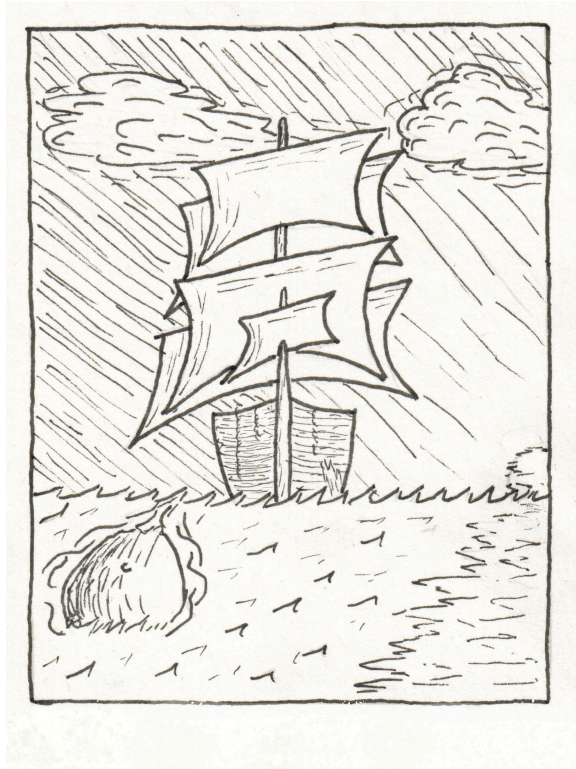
But returning to our pod of whales. Should a second beast be brought to spill its life along with the first, then the subsequent work of cutting and stripping and harvesting

should be twice as much for the crew, and should require remaining fastened in one place in the sea for twice as long as one body is lifted, skinned, and released, and the second is given the same treatment. But this forgets a key element to a ship: there is not one side, but two. The second carcass, instead of wasting away its time floating in the abyss, can be raised on the opposite side of the ship, and the crew can divide the labor of de-blanketing the beasts between them, so as to remain less time in a stationary state.

And when, the bodies having been set adrift to wander the seas, and the heads prepared for mooring to the sides, would it not be better to have a weight attached to both port and starboard, so that the ship may ride upright and balanced, drawn equally to the void in both directions? With a balanced keel, not unduly drawn to any direction, a ship may then proceed forwards and towards the next hunt without a great anchor pulling it forever in a circle, as though orbiting a whirlpool formed from the souls of slain leviathans, seeking vengeance on those who slew them. A ship captained by only one head may never leave the seas where it takes its first whale, and spin around that skull in circles, forever following the pull of a mind long devoid a soul.

There is little worse than a ship with only one head. For all of history no vessel has sailed the sea with but one man to provide guidance. Any who dared to venture alone, with only one captain at the helm, would inevitably vanish into the deep void of the sea. Were they stove in by a whale? By the White Whale himself? Or did they meet their fate on some unthought-of shore, among unknown peoples?

For many a year now, sailors who travel the seas will attest to the existence of one such ship, drifting at sea, unburdened by crew or purpose, and commanded by one alone,



not a man, but the haunted shadow of one. Having spoken this, they rarely say more willingly, but with enough drink, and proper encouragement I persuaded one man to give me the following tale:

“Somewhere in the east Pacific, our ship, the *Firelily* was sailing west towards the coast of Japan. It was the middle of the night, and only the night-watch, helmsman, and myself were awake. I had just turned away from the prow, when the lookout, from the top of the mast, cried out. Not hearing his words, I called up to him to inquire what he had seen. I was met with silence. When I turned around, not a hundred meters off our bow I saw a ship, sailing with no sails on the masts, oars on the sides, or other means of propulsion. There were no torches, no lanterns, no sources of light to be seen, and yet it glowed as though under a full moon, even on a night with no sign of any celestial bodies. No crew swarmed its deck, and I assume no passengers filled its hold. Only the captain, standing at the helm, grinning as though in death. I turned away to cry out to the helmsman, but as I turned back pointing at the apparition, it was gone.”

For clarity's sake, I must say that this story was extracted through not a few pokes with a sharp instrument, more than a little strong spirit, and perhaps some coins in the right hands, and I can in no way swear to the truth of this tale without a strong need to clean my mouth of its foul mistruths. However accurate this tale may be, does it not illustrate perfectly the result of a ship, following naught but a single head? This haunting spectre is dragged on by only a captain, sailing as a helmsman, and steering as a navigator.

May we be preserved from such a fate! Drawn as I am to the sea, I nevertheless have no desire to wander it tracklessly for an eternity, spectral as the dawn mist, and most probably under the command of one as devilishly single-minded as the lord of the planks on which I now stand. For at his will we would eternally hunt a devil to match the hunter, an endless chase of immortal after immortal, with no end save the burning of this world to make room for the next.

It may be thought that to avoid the curse of circling around a single head that it would be advantageous to take as many as possible; that it is best to bring down a score of whales and hang all of their heads by the ship-sides. Nothing could be further from that

which can be considered truth. For just as a single head will drag a ship round a single point like a whirlpool, so a score will drag the ship straight down into the abyss, with nothing but a few planks and barrels to mark its grave. It would serve us no more to have every mate, every harpooneer together at the helm than it does to leave the captain alone with his hell-seeking compass.

Were it but as simple as compelling him to accept the advice of another, or to replace him with a pair of our own choosing. But his fate, and his alone, is now ours, and there shall be no other to balance his cursed stroke of destiny. We cannot lift another head beside that of Ahab, or cast him back to the seas from whence he came. With a stroke of a pen, our lives were bound to his, our fates to the fate of the Pequod, and our ship to the endless hunt for the life of the White Whale. No other ship sails the dark seas sails with such an imbalance, one head binding the rest to its will, circling a vortex of doom.